

Photojournalism I

Craig Newmark Graduate School of Journalism

Syllabus Fall 2025

John Smock©

Course Doc

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Monday: 9:30a - 12:20p, rm 442
Office Hours: Weds 1-3p
and by appointment

COURSE DESCRIPTION

From the single social media image to high-end reportage, photojournalism is a powerful tool for communicating ideas important to journalism. Despite the ever-changing technologies and values in photojournalism that are transforming how news photography is produced, distributed and consumed, the strength of the still image remains undiminished. In fact, the market for stories communicated visually has never been stronger. New tools and the social media sphere have opened new opportunities for photographers creatively and professionally. Photographs, whether presented alone or as an essay in a multimedia context, continue to provide the photojournalists who make them a uniquely powerful window into the world in which we live and tools with which to tell stories.

This course builds on material introduced during the first semester. It is structured as a hands-on workshop. Instruction will progress from basic camera operation and the news “one shot” to more comprehensive visual storytelling. Using the journalism school’s Canon DSLRs (those who have equivalent cameras of their own are encouraged to use them), students will learn how to shoot portraits, cover news events and produce photo essays. The course will also teach post-production skills (Adobe Lightroom) and address how to present photos to editors and news outlets. The course is also intended as a complement to the advanced photojournalism course offered each fall.

The semester will be divided into two segments: single image stories, camera and technique (seven weeks); photo essay production, presentation and the pro marketplace (eight weeks). Students will be responsible for weekly assignments as well as *two long-term projects.

Some semesters the intro photo course produces photo assignments for an assortment of publications affiliated with the school, such as the Mott Haven Herald, the News services and local publications affiliated with the J-corp Visual Desk. Scheduling these assignments is not consistent but we will do our best to integrate assignments into course work for interested students.

**The final assignment instructions may change to accommodate a group project or work for other courses.*

Students are responsible for weekly readings, quizzes, tutorials, resource material and discussion.

Course content will include:

- An introduction to concepts and skills required to compose compelling images
- Discussion of the important role photography plays in the broader world of journalism

- Comprehensive instruction in the use of the Canon 60D dSLR, including an introduction to the school's robust selection of lenses, flashes and other accessories (students with comparable cameras of their own may use them)
- How to photograph the single-image news and feature assignment
- Techniques for developing, structuring and editing multi-image stories
- From memes, to social stories, photo's essential role in the social media sphere
- Photo workflow: how to edit, caption and organize large numbers of photos in Adobe Lightroom
- Tools and strategies for presenting work professionally.

GRADING

Grades for the course will be broken down as follows:

- First eight weekly assignments: **40 percent**
- First photo essay: **20 percent**
- Second photo essay: **20 percent**
- Class participation (including online discussions, professionalism and attendance: **20 percent**

Grading Rubric:

- **Images are filed on time and as instructed** - Properly Named. Filed by Deadline. In the correct Folder. The required number of images. Images are technically proficient (25 percent)
- **Images are properly exposed**. The subject is clearly focused. The images are properly sized and color corrected (as needed). Images fulfill assignment requirements (25 percent)
- **The image clearly illustrates the assignment** - They are carefully composed. If more than one, the images complement each other and tell a complete story.
- **Effort and creativity** - The images are creative, well-executed and compelling. Student contributes to critique. (25 percent)

Attendance is mandatory. See the [ACADEMIC CALENDAR](#) for the fall course schedule. Students who must miss a course should notify me beforehand. Extra credit is available to students who wish to do a 10-15 minutes presentation on a photographer of their choice. Other projects may be considered for extra credit.

Support for diversity in news coverage and in newsrooms is a fundamental value of the school and this course. Students, guest speakers and the instructor must all be comfortable discussing issues related to diversity. If something is said or done that a student feels is in violation of this principle please make the instructor or the Office of Academic Affairs aware.

It is school policy to provide Accommodations and Academic Adjustments to students with disabilities. Any student who has a disability who may need accommodations in this class should register as early as possible with the Office of Student Affairs in Room 307. Because of continued concern about Covid, health and personal safety remain important this semester. If you don't feel well, let me know and don't come to school. Zoom remains an option. If you test positive please let administration know.

COURSE MATERIAL

While news values and ethics in photojournalism does not appear as a specific topic in the outline below, we will discuss it frequently in the context of what is outlined.

Students must purchase the Adobe Lightroom from Adobe Creative Cloud prior to first class. This is the professional tool of post-processing software [Here is the direct link for students](#). Students who prefer to use Adobe Photoshop and complementary image management software (CMS) may do so.

Class One (9/8) - Introduction to Photojournalism

- Course overview
- Examples of Photo
- How to file assignments
- Intro to the Canon 60D
- Assignment #1

Class Two (9/15) - Post production tools and the pro camera bag

- Photographer of the Day
- Review of assignment #1
- The camera revisited
- An introduction to lenses
- Assignment #2

Class Three (9/29) - The environmental portrait and post-production software**

- Photographer of the day
- Review of assignment #2
- Shooting the environmental portrait
- Shooting the self-portrait
- An intro to Adobe Photoshop
- Assignment #3 -portrait/self-portrait

Class Four 10/6) - The News and Feature Assignments

- Photographer of the day
- Review of assignment #3
- News and Features
- Finding stories
- SPEAKER: TBA
- Assignment #4

Class Five (Tues 10/14) - Editing photographs**

- Photographer of the day
- Review of assignment #4
- Editing your own work
- An intro to editing stories for publication
- The [pitch form](#) and preparing for the photo essay
- Assignment #5

Class Six (Fri 10/24) - Story Structure and Editing and sequencing photos**

- Photographer of the day
- Review of assignment #5
- Ideas for an essay due
- Assignment #6

Class Seven (10/27) - Themes and personal style

- Photographer of the day
- Review of Assignment #6
- Professional style and personal vision
- Final idea for first photo essay due
- Assignment #7

Class Eight (11/3) - Exhibit Visit

- Begin shooting first essay
- Review of assignments #7
- *Review flash assignment

- Shoot essay #1, part #1

Class Nine (11/10) - An Intro to Studio Lighting

- Photographer of the day
- In-class studio workshop
- Review of first photo essay part #1
- Shoot essay #1, part #2

Class Ten (11/17) - Writing for Photographers

- Photographer of the Day
- Query letters, access letters and grant proposals
- Review of essay part #2
- Discussion of final essay/series with multimedia component
- The [pitch form](#) -- do final ideas for essay this week and finalize by next week
- Shoot essay #1, part #3

Class Eleven (11/24) - Photography and Archival Photo

- Photographer of the day
- Review of first essay part #3
- Archival uses for photo
- Workshop: sequencing of first photo essay
- Final essay idea due
- Shoot final essay part #1

Class Twelve (12/18) - Photo and Graphic Design

- Photographer of the day
- Tools for photo and Design
- Review of final essay part #1
- Shoot final essay part #2
- Workshop: upload final sequence first essay
- Speaker: TBA or workshop time to edit together

Class Thirteen (12/8) - The Professional World of Photojournalism

- Photographer of the day
- The Photo Portfolio
- Review of final essay part II with final multimedia component concept in place
- Assignment: final essay part 3
- Copyright and fair use of photographs
- What editors are looking for
 - Developing the portfolio site
 - Presentation tools
- Selling your work
 - PhotoShelter, Visura, Traditional or Boutique Agencies,
 - Native Agency, diversify.photo, Women Photograph, Others

Class Fourteen (12/15) - The future of photojournalism

- Emerging tools: AI, animations
- Experimental photo projects
- Changing pattern of distribution
- Review final photo essay part 3 (final)
- Workshop: edit and sequencing of final photo essay with multimedia component (upload)

Class Fifteen (12/22) - Review of Final projects

- Workshop: final touches on second essays/final projects

- Review of final projects